

How to Tame Mozilla Firefox

The Google Chrome invasion is now almost complete. Firefox is being used only by a band of die-hard enthusiasts. If you are one of them, this article will tell you how to overcome the most frustrating and annoying non-features in the browser.



Firefox is not dead yet. There still are users who are faithful to Mozilla's original promise to *take back the web*. Microsoft's Internet Explorer is resting in peace. Opera and Edge have become Chrome clones. Firefox is the only browser that has a non-Chrome HTML-rendering engine. However, in many other aspects, Mozilla is making Firefox more and more dependent on the Google universe. In this article, I will document how you can avoid that while continuing to use Firefox. I know this is a losing battle, but let's try and win it for now...

***about:config* changes are not effective**

Around the same time that Chrome was mopping up the browser market share, Firefox started annoying its users by disabling add-ons and breaking/disappearing functionality with every newly released version. Some users would modify the browser's internal settings in the *about:config* page to make Firefox function like it used to. For example, you could disable automatic updates by changing the *app.update.enabled* setting to false. Eventually, Mozilla got wise to these tricks and made the changes ineffective.

***policies.json* is the new alternative**

In corporate computer networks, end user software applications are installed and controlled by systems administrators. Application settings are also controlled by them. Most end users or desktop users are given lesser

privileges. They cannot install software on their own. They may not even be able to customise the software.

To give administrators the ability to control Firefox installations, Mozilla has created support for a global configuration file named *policies.json*. This file is usually installed in a privileged location such as */etc/firefox/policies/policies.json*. Someone with desktop-user privileges will not be able to modify this file.

While Firefox may ignore your changes to *about:config* settings, it will honour directives in the *policies.json* file. If you are the administrator of your computer, you can lock down Firefox and make it behave the way that you want it to. You need to create a customised version of this *policies.json* file in the */etc/firefox/policies* directory. Firefox will then think that you are in a corporate environment and be tricked into implementing the setting changes.

The *policies.json* file is written like the value of a JavaScript variable (with a JSON structure):

```
{    "policies": {
        "blah": "blah",
        "blah blah": 1,
        "blah blah blah": false
    }
}
```

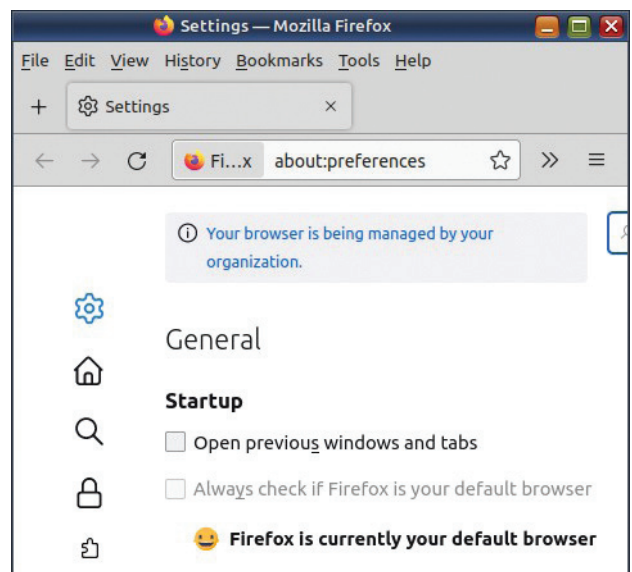


Figure 1: When a *policies.json* file exists, Firefox preferences will become limited by it